Q. What is your stand on the abrogation of Article 370?



"They have given Article 370 a bad name as though it was some great robbery. It is a federal solution, and is not anti-national or secessionist"

— SAJAD LONE

● **OMAR ABDULLAH:** We have talked of restoring Article 370 but we are realistic enough to know it's not going to come out of this assembly. It's not going to come back from this government. The point we make to people is that look, it took the BJP decades to reach a point where they could write it down. The battle to try and get it restored is not going to end tomorrow. So, it's not the be-all and end-all of our campaign, which also deals with all the day to day issues.

● **MEHBOOBA MUFTI:** Any government in the country that wants to resolve the Kashmir issue will have to start from restoring 370. This is the bridge for the gap between Jammu and Kashmir and the rest of the country. They had broken it.

● **JITENDRA SINGH:** This is an issue which forms a subject of rhetoric only for two or three political parties like the PDP and the NC. It is not an issue with the common man in Kashmir, because now he's begun to realise that 370 did not help him. It helped only a handful of individuals who are the most vociferous votaries of Article 370 today but who were also its greatest abusers to perpetuate their rule.

● **TARIQ HAMEED KARRA** History will show that it was the Congress Party that gave Article 370, but not out of charity. It was a negotiated article between the tallest leaders of India and J&K at that time. If people in power now say they are too touchy about Article 370, there are other ways we could be given what it contained. We are not concerned about the number 370, we are concerned about our lost and robbed rights. We want those things in any form which the Constitution has already bestowed to the northeastern states, to Himachal and other progressing states.

● **ENGINEER RASHID:** Article 370 had already been diluted by the Congress, NC and the PDP. Every law that Parliament passes gets implemented here. Had they really any respect for Article 370, the state assembly would never have extended UAPA to J&K or given access to central agencies in J&K. They should never have implemented GST. But for us, Article 370 is key. It's a bridge between Jammu and Kashmir and the rest of the country. It has to be restored.

● **SAJAD LONE:** They have given Article 370 a bad name as if it was a great robbery or something. Article 370 is a federal solution, and you have many such federal solutions in many civilised parts across the world. It's not anti-national or secessionist. Federal solutions in fact act as buffers and dilute secessionist sentiments. I believe that future generations in India would invest in federalism across the country and heavily in Kashmir.

● **ALTAF BUKHARI:** Nobody can get back 370 through bullet or even the ballot. It can be only through political negotiation. Taking the issue to court was the biggest mistake. Political issues must be settled by the political leadership.

● **RAVINDER RAINA:** Dr Farooq Abdullah says he will restore 370 but also says it will take 100 years to do it. Parliament and the courts have approved the abrogation of Article 370 and it is irreversible. ■



"Kashmiri citizens, particularly aspirational youth, would not like to miss the bus driven by PM Modi that has made India an attractive destination for employment"

— JITENDRA SINGH